Kenya **Manufacturing & Industry** Sector Report 2026

Strategic Insights for Industrial Growth, Production Systems, and Value Chains in Kenya

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KENYA 2026
MANUFACTURING & INDUSTRY INTELLIGENCE BRIEF

Manufacturing's share of GDP peaked at 13% two decades ago. Today it is 7.3%. The sector grows at 2% while the economy grows at 5%. *Kenya is deindustrialising before it ever industrialised.*

Derived from the Kenya 2026 Economic Outlook | Econsult Africa Sector Intelligence Series

Section 1: Macro Context in 60 Seconds

The Outlook frames Kenya's manufacturing challenge with a term from Dani Rodrik's economic theory: **"premature deindustrialisation."** This describes countries that are losing manufacturing's share of GDP at much lower income levels than the advanced economies that underwent classical industrialisation. Kenya fits precisely. Manufacturing peaked at approximately 13% of GDP in the early 2000s and has since declined to 7.3%, even as per capita income remains under $2,000 (Econsult Africa, 2026; KAM, 2026). Manufacturing growth averaged approximately 2% through 2025 — well below headline GDP of 5% — meaning the sector's economic weight continued to shrink (Trading Economics, 2026).

Why should anyone at a bar care about this? Because **manufacturing is the sector with the highest employment multiplier of any in the economy**. Each manufacturing job creates 2-3 ancillary jobs in services and logistics. Without it, Kenya's growth model relies on services (which tend toward winner-take-all dynamics and skills polarisation) and agriculture (which is climate-dependent). The structural consequences are profound: youth unemployment estimated at 40-67% for those under 35 is not an accident. It is the direct result of growing an economy without the sector that historically absorbs unskilled and semi-skilled labour at scale. The Kenya Vision 2030 industrialisation targets are increasingly disconnected from reality. The more realistic path, the Outlook suggests, may be "manufacturing-adjacent" activities — food processing, light assembly, packaging, and industrial services that leverage Kenya's advantages in logistics, digital infrastructure, and an English-speaking workforce — rather than classical heavy industrialisation (Econsult Africa, 2026).

Since the Outlook was completed, three developments have intensified the pressure. First, AGOA was renewed on February 3, 2026, but only for one year through December 31, 2026, the shortest-ever authorisation — a "reprieve rather than a renewal" leaving approximately 66,000 EPZ jobs in limbo (Econsult Africa, 2026; Tuko, 2026). Second, Bangladesh was granted zero-tariff access to the US market for apparel, directly undercutting Kenya's AGOA advantage at a moment when Kenya already carries a 20% structural cost disadvantage (Tuko, 2026). Third, the oil shock since February 28 has pushed energy and transport costs sharply higher at exactly the moment manufacturers can least absorb them. The Kenya Association of Manufacturers launched its Manufacturing Priority Agenda 2026 in February, targeting 20% GDP contribution by 2030, $10 billion in FDI, and exports to 30% of output. The gap between 7.3% actual and 20% target is the widest of any Vision 2030 objective (KAM, 2026; Capital FM, 2026).

> *This brief draws primarily on the Kenya 2026 Economic Outlook by Econsult Africa, supplemented by publicly available data through March 29, 2026. All 2026 projections are forward-looking assessments.*

For the full macroeconomic analysis, see the Kenya 2026 Economic Outlook (https://econsult.africa/kenya-2026).

Section 2: Sector Performance and Trajectory

The Paradox: Too Important to Ignore, Too Weak to Transform

Manufacturing contributes approximately 7.3% of GDP by KAM's narrow measure and roughly 11% by the broader ISIC definition. Either way, it is shrinking relative to the economy. Growth of roughly 2% in 2025 against headline GDP of 5% means manufacturing is being structurally displaced by services (Econsult Africa, 2026; Trading Economics, 2026). The constraints are well-documented and mutually reinforcing: energy costs among the highest in East Africa despite geothermal advantages; a skills pipeline producing graduates mismatched with industrial needs; infrastructure gaps in rail, port efficiency, and industrial zones raising logistics costs; and regulatory complexity and corruption burdening the business environment. The tariff and trade environment adds a new dimension in 2026. Chinese manufacturing overcapacity, particularly in steel, cement, textiles, and electronics, is flooding African markets through a 26.2% surge in Chinese exports to Africa documented in the Outlook. The Kenya Manufacturers Association has repeatedly flagged this competitive challenge (Econsult Africa, 2026).

Simultaneously, a January 2026 China-Kenya early harvest arrangement grants duty-free access to 98.2% of Kenyan exports entering China — an opportunity that requires active industrial policy to translate into export gains rather than simply deeper import penetration. Chinese FDI in Kenya is showing nascent presence in light manufacturing: ceramics, batteries, tissue, alongside ventures in automotive and machinery assembly (BU Global Development, 2026). But a more complex industrial base through FDI has yet to emerge at scale. The China debt reprofile saves Kenya approximately $215 million annually in debt service by extending maturities and shifting to lower-cost RMB financing, but improving Kenya's long-term debt sustainability will depend on strengthening export capacity and attracting productive investment (BU Global Development, 2026).

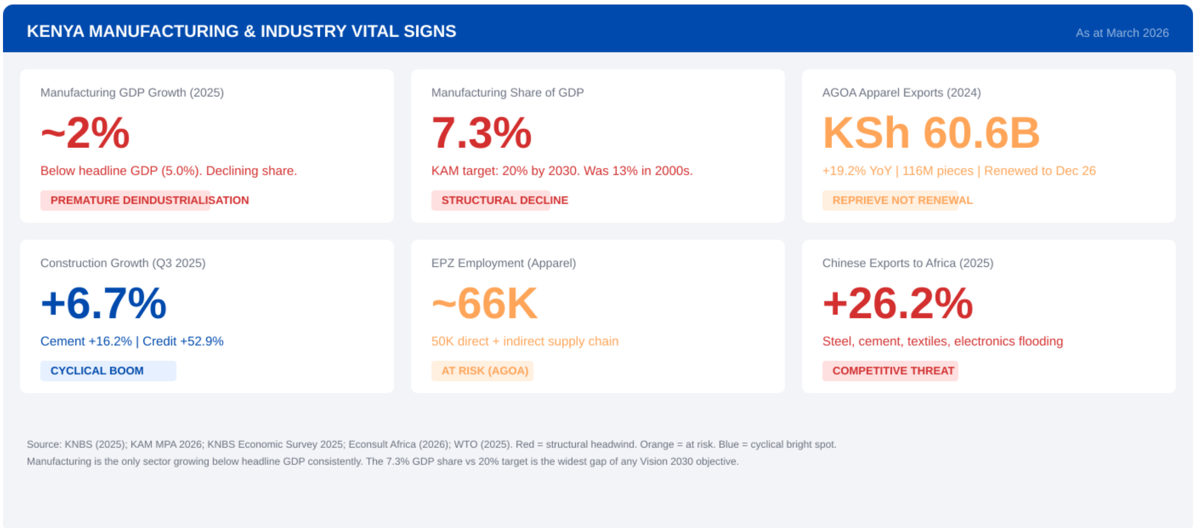

Figure 1: Manufacturing & Industry Vital Signs Dashboard. Red indicators dominate. This is the only sector where no KPI is coded blue (structurally positive). Construction is the cyclical exception.

The AGOA Lifeline: Counting Down to December 31

AGOA is the most consequential trade policy for Kenya's manufacturing sector. Under its duty-free provisions, Kenya's apparel exports to the US grew from $55 million in 2001 to $603 million in 2022. In 2024, AGOA-linked apparel exports earned KSh 60.6 billion ($470 million), up 19.2%, with 116 million pieces shipped from 36 EPZ firms employing approximately 66,000 workers with capital investment of KSh 24.88 billion (KNBS Economic Survey, 2025; Agoa.info, 2025; Kohan Textile Journal, 2025). Kenya is the second-largest AGOA apparel exporter, capturing 23.2% of the market. Textile and apparel accounts for 94% of Kenya's total AGOA exports, and EPZ garment firms account for over 50% of EPZ employment. The sector has seen steady growth in capital investment, with a 7.2% increase from 2018 to 2022 (IEA Kenya, 2023; Agoa.info, 2025).

The one-year renewal through December 31, 2026, with 10% Trump reciprocal tariffs layered on top, creates what EPZ Apparel Sector Chair Pankaj Bedi calls a "competitiveness crisis, not a competitiveness window" (Tuko, 2026). Apparel manufacturing operates on seasonal order cycles of 4-6 months. By mid-2026, buyers placing orders for the next season need to know whether AGOA will exist in 2027. If it does not, **orders simply move to Bangladesh, Vietnam, or Ethiopia**. The structural problem is deeper: Kenya carries a 20% cost disadvantage versus competitors, driven by energy, logistics, financing, and compliance overheads. AGOA's duty-free access partially compensated for this gap. Without it, Kenyan apparel is commercially unviable for sustained sourcing. Add a 10% tariff disadvantage and buyers respond to arithmetic, not sentiment. As Bedi warns: Kenya risks becoming an opportunity-buy market, used intermittently rather than strategically (Tuko, 2026).

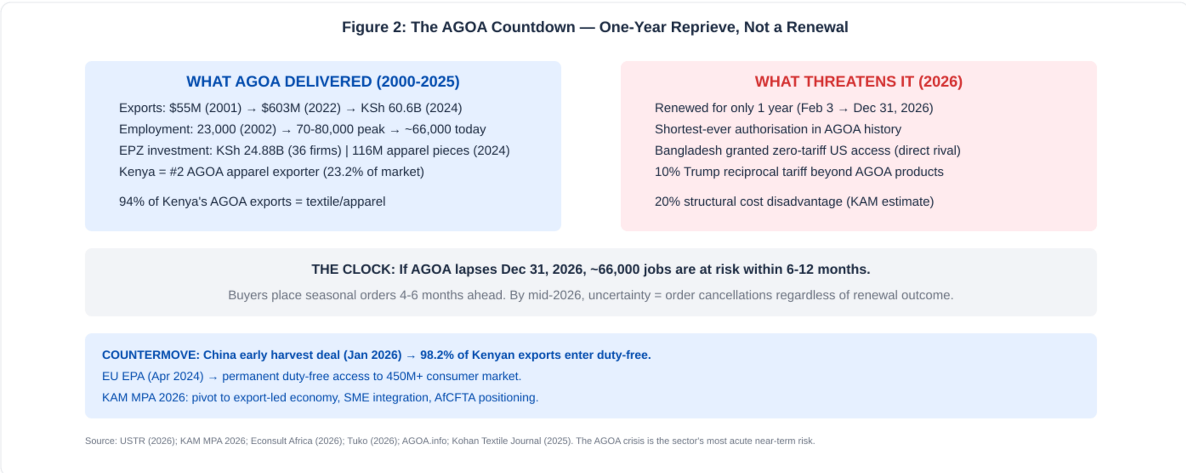

Figure 2: The AGOA Countdown. 25 years of growth threatened by a single-year renewal. Bangladesh's zero-tariff US access directly undercuts Kenya's competitive position.

The Bright Spot: Construction Materials

Construction was the industrial sector's star in 2025, rebounding 6.7% in Q3 from contraction throughout 2024. Cement consumption surged 16.2% to 2,664 thousand tonnes; iron and steel imports jumped to 336,262 tonnes from 220,284; credit to construction rose 52.9% to KSh 195.3 billion (Econsult Africa, 2026). This drives demand across construction materials manufacturers: cement producers (Bamburi, East African Portland, Mombasa Cement), steel fabricators, paint manufacturers, and packaging companies. Key subsectors include food and beverage processing (the largest manufacturing subsector, driven by Brookside Dairy, BIDCO, Kenya Breweries, Del Monte), chemicals and pharmaceuticals, paper and packaging, and automotive assembly including Isuzu East Africa and Associated Vehicle Assemblers (Huduma Global, 2026). **But construction's contribution is cyclical, not structural.** Pre-election infrastructure spending will be front-loaded into 2026-early 2027. The historical pattern reverses post-election as new administrations review contracts and pending bills accumulate.

Mining: Small Base, Big Recovery

Mining and quarrying recovered 16.6% in Q3 2025 from a deep contraction of -12.2% in Q3 2024, driven by soda ash, fluorspar, and quarry stones. The sector's GDP share is approximately 1%, so even large percentage swings have limited macro impact. However, Kenya's nascent extractive potential (titanium in Kwale, recently discovered oil in Turkana, geothermal resources in the Rift Valley) represents medium-term optionality requiring sustained policy attention (Econsult Africa, 2026).

Section 3: Policy and Regulatory Environment

KAM's MPA 2026: The Roadmap Without a Road

The Kenya Association of Manufacturers launched MPA 2026 in February, anchored on four pillars: global competitiveness, export-led industrialisation, SME development, and agriculture for industry (KAM, 2026; Capital FM, 2026). The targets — 20% GDP contribution by 2030, exports to 30%, $10 billion FDI — are ambitious against the 7.3% baseline. Principal Secretary Susan Mangeni confirmed BETA alignment, but execution speed is the binding constraint. The persistent structural drags: high energy costs (industrial electricity above East African peers despite geothermal capacity), delayed VAT refunds straining manufacturer cash flow (a recurring complaint in KAM's advocacy), overlapping regulatory burdens across multiple county and national agencies, and non-tariff barriers within the EAC and AfCFTA that prevent goods flowing freely across borders despite trade agreements.

Trade Architecture: A Rapid Reconfiguration

Kenya's manufacturing trade environment is being reshaped simultaneously by four frameworks. AGOA provides the US lifeline but only for one more year. The EU EPA (ratified April 2024) delivers permanent duty-free access to a 450-million-consumer market — the structural trade certainty that AGOA does not provide. The China early harvest deal (January 2026) grants 98.2% access, and the Changsha Declaration (June 2025) signalled China's intention to eliminate tariffs for 53 African countries beginning May 2026 (BU Global Development, 2026). AfCFTA is slowly operationalising, with 38.3% of Kenya's KSh 1.1 trillion in goods exports already destined for African markets (KAM, 2026). The Outlook notes this creates both opportunity (supply chain diversification, friend-shoring as global firms seek alternatives to China for African markets) and threat (Chinese import surge displacing domestic manufacturers). Translating trade access into manufacturing growth requires competitive energy costs, functioning infrastructure, and industrial policy — none of which materialise automatically from trade agreements.

The Oil Shock Amplifies the Structural Constraint

Manufacturing's most persistent structural constraint — high energy costs — is being amplified by the oil shock. With Brent at $112 versus the Outlook's assumed $58-67, energy input costs for manufacturers are rising at exactly the moment competitive pressure from Chinese imports is intensifying. Kenya's 90% renewable electricity grid provides partial insulation for electricity-intensive processes, but transport, logistics, and thermal processes (cement kilns, steel working, food processing) remain oil-dependent. KenGen's Green Energy Park at Olkaria (gazetted as an SEZ) offers the structural answer: industrial operations powered by clean, competitively-priced geothermal energy. A fourth investor was onboarded in March 2026. But it is a medium-term solution to an immediate cost crisis (Econsult Africa, 2026; KenGen, 2026).

Section 4: Risk Map

Manufacturing carries the **densest concentration of high-impact risks of any sector except energy**. Three risks (AGOA, Chinese imports, oil costs) cluster in the high-impact zone simultaneously. One is already active.

Risk 1: AGOA Expiry / Non-Renewal (Probability: Medium | Impact: Severe for apparel)

The one-year renewal expires December 31, 2026. **Trigger:** Non-renewal by Congress; USTR "modernisation" conditions unacceptable; US political shift. **Early warning:** Buyer order cancellations from mid-2026; EPZ investment freezes; factory pre-closure notices; USTR policy statements. Apparel operates on 4-6 month order cycles, so **by July 2026 the damage begins regardless of the December outcome**. **Transmission:** ~66,000 direct jobs; KSh 60.6 billion in export revenue; multiplier effects through the supply chain including packaging, buttons, laundry services, logistics. Bangladesh's zero-tariff access makes order reallocation immediate (Econsult Africa, 2026; Tuko, 2026; Kohan Textile Journal, 2025).

Risk 2: Chinese Import Surge (Probability: High | Impact: Medium-High, structural)

26.2% growth in Chinese exports to Africa in 2025. Steel, cement, textiles, electronics flooding Kenyan markets at prices domestic manufacturers cannot match. **Trigger:** Continued Chinese manufacturing overcapacity driven by weak domestic demand redirecting exports to Africa and the Global South. **Early warning:** KNBS import data showing accelerating Chinese manufactured goods volumes; KAM surveys reporting competitive displacement; factory closure announcements in affected subsectors. **Transmission:** Domestic manufacturers lose market share; import substitution reverses; manufacturing GDP share continues its structural decline. The Outlook notes that Chinese overcapacity in steel, cement, textiles, and electronics is particularly relevant to Kenya's manufacturing base (Econsult Africa, 2026; WTO, 2025).

Risk 3: Oil-Driven Input Cost Surge (Status: ACTIVE | Impact: Medium-High)

Brent at $112 raises energy, transport, and logistics costs for all manufacturers. **Status:** Active since February 28. **Early warning:** EPRA pricing cycles; manufacturer margin compression; input cost indices. **Transmission:** Thin-margin manufacturers (textiles, plastics, food processing) face profitability crisis. Cement producers face kiln energy cost increases. Oil-intensive value chains (cold chain, transport, thermal processing) are most exposed. The pass-through to consumer prices compounds the Retail & Consumer risks analysed in Brief 8.

Risk 4: Post-Election Construction Cliff (Probability: High | Impact: Medium for materials)

Historical pattern: infrastructure spending collapses post-election. **Trigger:** August 2027 election. **Early warning:** Pending bills exceeding KSh 200 billion; cement consumption decelerating; FY2027/28 budget allocation shifts. **Transmission:** Construction materials sector (the cyclical bright spot) reverses from boom to contraction. Cement, steel, and paint manufacturers face demand cliff, potentially coinciding with elevated input costs.

Risk 5: Skills Mismatch (Probability: High | Impact: Medium, structural)

Kenya's education system produces graduates mismatched with industrial needs. TVET remains underfunded relative to demand. **Trigger:** Structural, not event-driven. The mismatch persists because educational reform operates on 5-10 year cycles while industrial needs evolve continuously. **Transmission:** Constrains manufacturing productivity growth and limits Kenya's ability to attract supply-chain diversification from Asia. Friend-shoring opportunities go to Ethiopia and Tanzania, which offer lower wages to compensate for similar skills gaps (Econsult Africa, 2026).

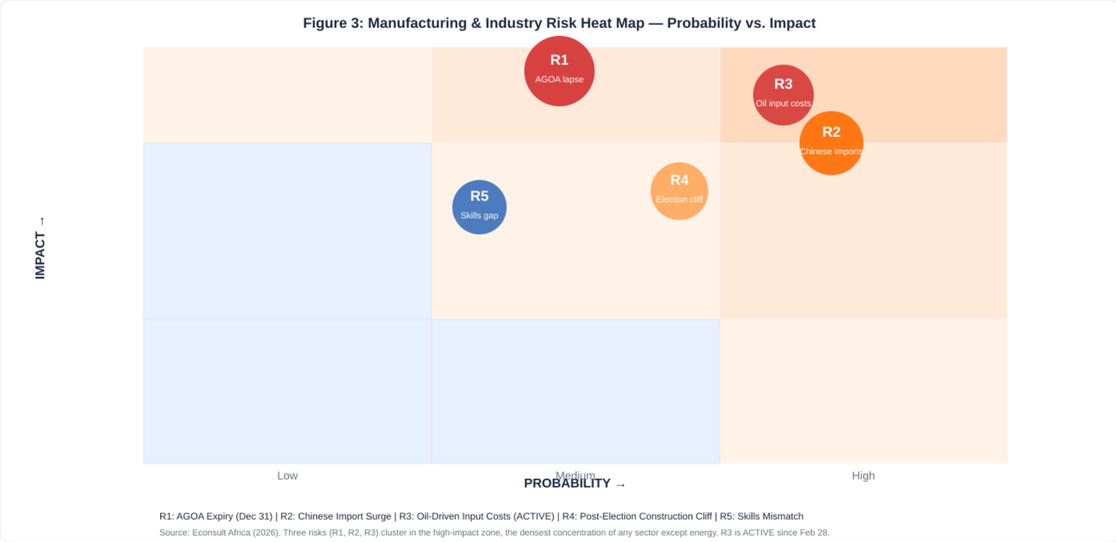

Figure 3: Risk Heat Map. Three risks cluster in the high-impact zone — the densest concentration of any sector in the series. R3 (oil costs) is already active. R1 (AGOA) has a specific deadline: December 31, 2026.

Section 5: Opportunity Map

O1: Food Processing & Agro-Industrial Value Addition (3-7 years)

Thesis: Kenya's largest manufacturing subsector (food and beverage processing) is the most natural growth pathway. It leverages agricultural inputs, serves domestic demand (54 million consumers with growing urbanisation), and benefits from AfCFTA regional access. Companies like Brookside Dairy, BIDCO, Kenya Breweries, and Del Monte demonstrate the model. Value addition to horticulture, dairy, and cereals increases both export revenue per tonne and domestic employment. **Evidence:** Dairy deliveries growing 9.7% (Q3 2025); horticulture exports +36.2%; growing middle-class demand for processed and packaged foods. **Risk:** Raw material supply volatility (climate-dependent for agricultural inputs); competition from South African and Egyptian food manufacturers with greater scale. **Time horizon:** Structural (Econsult Africa, 2026; Huduma Global, 2026).

O2: Supply Chain Diversification / Friend-Shoring (2-5 years)

Thesis: Global supply chain fragmentation creates "friend-shoring" dynamics that could benefit Kenya. English-speaking workforce, relatively strong institutions, digital infrastructure (M-Pesa, mobile penetration), and EAC market access position Kenya as a potential assembly and light manufacturing hub for companies diversifying away from China. **Evidence:** Isuzu, Volkswagen, and Simba Corp have assembly operations. Chinese FDI emerging in ceramics, batteries, tissue, automotive (BU Global Development, 2026). 105 gazetted EPZs with KSh 171.9 billion capital investment and 180 operating enterprises (Huduma Global, 2026). **Risk:** 20% cost disadvantage versus competitors; Ethiopian and Tanzanian competition offering lower wages. **Time horizon:** Medium-term. This is the Outlook's "manufacturing-adjacent" thesis.

O3: Pre-Election Construction Materials Boom (6-18 months, cyclical)

Thesis: Cement +16.2%, steel imports +52.6%, construction credit +52.9%. Pre-election spending is accelerating: roads, AFCON stadiums, Affordable Housing, county projects. Cement, steel, paint, and building materials manufacturers benefit directly. **Risk:** Post-election cliff is the documented historical pattern. Oil shock raises kiln energy costs for cement producers. **Time horizon: EXIT BEFORE AUGUST 2027.** This is explicitly cyclical (Econsult Africa, 2026). Investors and operators who mistake cyclical demand for structural growth will face a sharp reversal.

O4: SEZ / Green Energy Park Manufacturing (long-term)

Thesis: KenGen's Olkaria Green Energy Park, gazetted as an SEZ, offers industrial tenants geothermal-powered operations at competitively priced energy. In a $100+ oil world, the cost advantage of geothermal manufacturing is amplified. This directly addresses the structural energy cost constraint that KAM and the Outlook identify as the binding constraint. **Evidence:** Fourth investor onboarded March 2026; EPZ programme track record (105 zones, KSh 171.9 billion investment). **Risk:** Infrastructure and water availability at Olkaria; distance from Nairobi logistics hub. **Time horizon:** Long-term (KenGen, 2026; Huduma Global, 2026).

O5: AGOA Pivot — EU and China Market Diversification (urgent, 0-12 months)

Thesis: The AGOA uncertainty is a strategic catalyst for Kenya to diversify its apparel export markets beyond the US. The EU EPA provides permanent duty-free access to 450 million consumers. The China early harvest deal provides 98.2% market access. AfCFTA opens the continental market. Manufacturers who pivot now reduce dependency on a single, politically volatile trade framework. **Evidence:** EU EPA ratified April 2024; China deal January 2026; KAM MPA 2026 explicitly targeting export diversification; Kenya exported KSh 1.1 trillion in goods with 38.3% to African markets. **Risk:** EU and Chinese consumers have different quality and style requirements; retooling takes time; order pipelines take 6-12 months to build. **Time horizon:** Urgent. Every month of delay increases AGOA dependency risk (Tuko, 2026; BU Global Development, 2026).

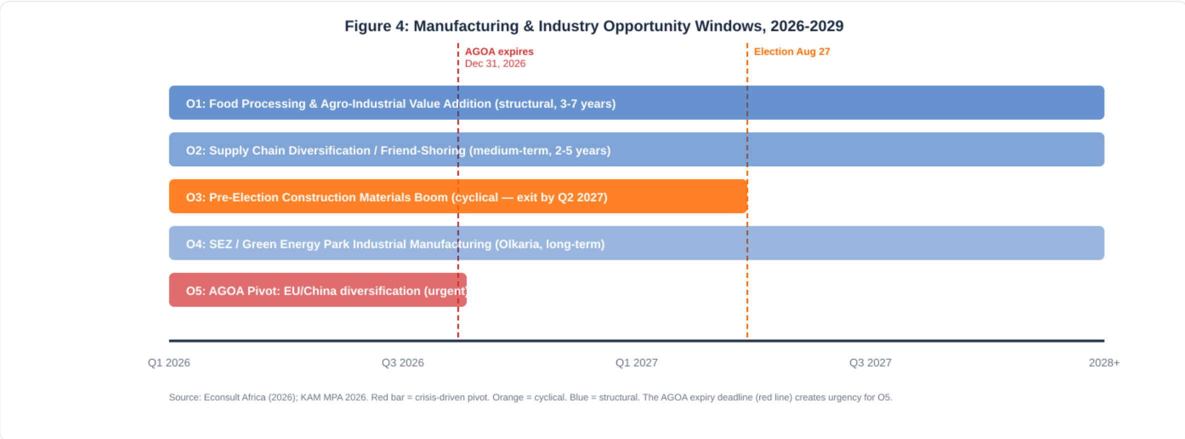

Figure 4: Opportunity Windows. The AGOA expiry deadline (red vertical line, Dec 31, 2026) creates urgency for O5. O3 has the same cyclical exit trigger as the Banking, Energy, and Real Estate briefs: August 2027.

Section 6: So What: Implications by Player Type

For Operators (manufacturers, EPZ firms, construction materials)

If you are an AGOA-dependent apparel manufacturer, begin EU and China market development immediately. The one-year renewal buys time, not certainty. Buyers placing orders from mid-2026 onward need confidence that Kenyan supply will be available post-December. Start with EU buyers: the EPA provides permanent access and the quality standards are well-established. **For construction materials producers:** maximise the pre-election boom but model for post-August 2027 demand contraction. Build inventory while demand is strong, lock material supplier contracts, and manage receivables aggressively (pending bills are the cash flow killer). **For all manufacturers:** the oil shock raises input costs across the board. Hedge where possible, invest in energy efficiency, and seriously evaluate the Olkaria SEZ for energy-intensive operations. The 20% cost disadvantage that Bedi identifies will not be solved by trade agreements alone.

For Investors (manufacturing equity, EPZs, industrial real estate)

Manufacturing is Kenya's most structurally challenged sector. Even the upside scenario projects growth below headline GDP. Investment thesis must be highly selective: food processing (structural demand from 54 million consumers and growing urbanisation), construction materials (cyclical but visible, with clear exit timing), and SEZ-based manufacturing (geothermal energy cost advantage). **Avoid broad manufacturing equity exposure** unless you have conviction on AGOA renewal AND oil price resolution. **The China early harvest deal** creates a new export pathway that has not yet been priced into any Kenyan manufacturer's valuation. Industrial real estate in Tatu City, Tilisi, and Athi River is an emerging sub-asset class benefiting from both manufacturing and logistics demand.

For Policymakers (MoITED, KAM, EPZA, National Treasury)

The 20% structural cost disadvantage is the binding constraint. No trade agreement compensates for uncompetitive costs. MPA 2026's four pillars are the right framework; execution speed determines whether the 7.3% share continues declining or stabilises. **Accelerate VAT refunds** to relieve manufacturer cash flow pressure — this is the most frequently cited near-term constraint by KAM members. **Implement Buy Kenya Build Kenya with enforcement teeth** to give domestic manufacturers preferential access to government procurement. **Resolve AGOA at the diplomatic level** while simultaneously building EU, China, and AfCFTA market pipelines so that no single trade framework determines the sector's fate. The one-year AGOA renewal is both a deadline and a wake-up call.

For Development Partners (IFC, UNIDO, AfDB)

Manufacturing is where Kenya's employment crisis meets its structural transformation deficit. The highest-impact interventions are TVET strengthening (closing the skills mismatch that constrains both productivity and attractiveness for friend-shoring investment), SME supplier development (integrating local firms into EPZ and multinational supply chains), energy cost reduction (supporting geothermal-powered industrial zones), and credit guarantee schemes for manufacturing SMEs. The premature deindustrialisation thesis means Kenya risks permanently skipping the industrialisation stage that historically drives broad-based employment growth. DFI-supported industrial policy must address this structural challenge, not just fund individual projects.

Section 7: Key Indicators to Watch

Indicator	Current Value	Trend	Threshold	Source	Freq.
Manufacturing growth	~2% (2025)	▼ Below GDP	Below 1.5% for 2 qtrs	KNBS	Quarterly
Mfg share of GDP	7.3%	▼ Declining	Falls below 7%	KAM/KNBS	Annual
AGOA status	Renewed to Dec 31	Uncertain	Non-renewal signal	USTR	As needed
AGOA apparel exports	KSh 60.6B (2024)	▲ +19.2%	Order cancellations	KNBS	Annual
EPZ employment	~66,000 (apparel)	↔ At risk	Factory closure notices	EPZA	Quarterly
Chinese imports	+26.2% (2025)	▲ Surging	Acceleration above 30%	KNBS/WTO	Quarterly
Construction growth	6.7% (Q3 2025)	▲ Cyclical	Deceleration below 3%	KNBS	Quarterly
Cement consumption	+16.2% YoY	▲ Booming	Decline for 2 months	KNBS	Monthly
Brent crude	$112.57 (Mar 27)	▲ CRISIS	Sustained >$95	Trading Econ.	Daily
MPA 2026 progress	Launched Feb 26	New	No measurable progress Q3	KAM	Quarterly

Figure 5: Manufacturing Under Three Macro Scenarios (2026)

SCENARIO	MFG GROWTH	AGOA STATUS	OIL / INPUTS	SECTOR VERDICT
UPSIDE AGOA renewed + oil resolves	**3-4%** Still below headline GDP	Multi-year renewal Investment confidence returns	Hormuz reopens; oil <$75 Input costs normalise	STABILISE
BASELINE 1-yr AGOA + elevated oil	**2-2.5%** Continued decline in share	1-year only (current) Uncertainty suppresses investment	Oil $80-95; energy costs rise Margins compressed	ERODE
DOWNSIDE AGOA lapses + oil sustained	**<1%** Approaching stagnation	Expires Dec 31, 2026 ~66K jobs at risk within 12 months	Oil >$100 sustained + Chinese import surge continues	COLLAPSE

Source: Econsult Africa (2026); KAM MPA 2026. Even the upside scenario projects manufacturing below headline GDP growth. This is the only sector where the best case is still underperformance.

Figure 5: Even the upside scenario projects manufacturing below headline GDP growth. This is the only sector where the best case is still underperformance. The downside (AGOA + oil) approaches stagnation.

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Methodology

This brief is derived from the Kenya 2026 Economic Outlook, a comprehensive macroeconomic assessment by Econsult Africa, supplemented by publicly available data through March 2026. All sources are cited in APA 7th edition format. All 2026 sector-level projections remain forward-looking assessments as at the date of publication.

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